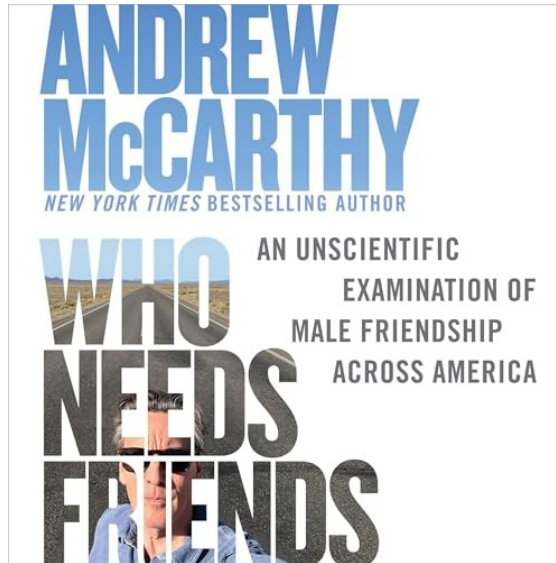


Who Needs Friends?

An Unscientific Examination of Male Friendship Across America
by Andrew McCarthy



Showing up is the whole thing.

McCarthy keeps hearing the same phrase from men whose friendships have lasted: they show up. Bob in Paris, Kentucky said it plainly — “If something happens to someone in this corps, I’m there. And shame on you if you’re not there when they need you.” McCarthy’s friend Sevy was housebound and humiliated by his clutter, and McCarthy just kept driving down to Baltimore, kept knocking, kept emptying boxes. The friendship wasn’t saved by a perfect text or a thoughtful gift. He just kept turning up.

Don’t schedule. Just go.

Every time McCarthy tried to plan a visit with one of his old friends, the visit got cancelled. Work came up, kids needed something, the back was bad, the timing was off. So he stopped asking and started showing up unannounced. Sevy panicked, Matthew protested, but McCarthy was already in the car. If you wait until everyone’s calendar lines up, you’ll never go.

Friendship isn’t intense, it’s normal.

Larry Wright in Austin tells McCarthy: “Friendship is not intense. It’s normal. It’s routine. It’s habit.” Most men think they need to schedule a special trip or have a heart-to-heart for friendship to count. They don’t. The friends you’d call at 3 a.m. aren’t the ones with whom you had the most important conversation last year — they’re the ones you see for coffee on Tuesdays without making a thing of it.

Don't pull punches.

Eddie tells McCarthy in Texas: "When you start to pull punches, it starts the deterioration of the relationship." Polite friends are dying friends. The men in this book whose friendships lasted decades were the ones who told each other the truth — even when it stung, even when they had to apologize for it later. Aristotle wasn't wrong: friendship without honesty is something else.

Vulnerability comes before trust.

Most men think trust is built first and vulnerability comes after. John in Wyoming — a guy who climbs Himalayan peaks — tells McCarthy it's the opposite: "You got to walk through the door of vulnerability to get to trust." McCarthy and John became close because John shared a long-held secret early. Trust didn't slowly accumulate. One man went first.

Your kids are watching.

The whole book started because McCarthy's 21-year-old son Sam looked at him at the kitchen table and said, "You don't really have any friends, do you, dad?" McCarthy realized his lack of male friendship wasn't just hurting him — it was modeling a small life for his kids. If your son grows up watching you not call your friends, he'll do the same.

The lone wolf myth is killing men.

Jimmy in Boise puts it bluntly: "That whole lone wolf is a myth that should die." 15% of American men say they have no close friends, up from 3% in 1990. The Surgeon General has declared an epidemic of loneliness. The macho ideal of the silent self-sufficient man — John Wayne, Carl on his motorcycle alone in the desert — comes with a body count.

Friends carry weight a spouse can't.

At a gas station in Winslow, Arizona, McCarthy notices that the relief his male friends give him lands differently from the support his wife provides. Both are real. But men carry a near-universal weight of feeling responsible to provide and protect, and a male friend can shrug at that with you in a way that doesn't require explanation. Eddie just nods. That nod does work no spouse can do.

Just keep shoveling.

John was going through a brutal divorce when McCarthy called him one day, found him shoveling snow in the driveway, and said "just keep shoveling, dude." Years later, John still uses it as his mantra during hard moments. The best friends give you a portable phrase you can take into bad days. Find one and pass it on.

It's not too late.

McCarthy started this trip terrified he had let his oldest friendships atrophy past the point of saving. He hadn't seen Sevy or Matthew or Eddie in years. The book's punchline is that none of them held it against him. Friendship is more durable than men give it credit for — show up, even if it's been a decade, and most of the time the door opens.